

RELIGIOUS PLURALISM AND THE PROBLEM OF ABSOLUTE TRUTH

FOUR AXES OF DIVERSITY → EXCLUSIVISM-INCLUSIVISM-PLURALISM → JOHN HICK → VEDĀNTIC MODELS → JAIN MANY-SIDEDNESS → TOLERANCE AND RELIGIOUS FREEDOM

Read the thick cyan rail from Stage 00 to the final core synthesis. Each card uses a concept-appropriate structure; the grey E card is optional enrichment only and never repairs missing core content.

PRIMARY CORE FLOW SUBORDINATE EXTRA APPROVAL / REVIEW

Approval: FALSE • Pending user review • source generation g13 and all prior artifacts unchanged

CORE BEFORE EXTRA • prior artefacts unchanged • exact same master drives poster and tiles

00

STAGE 00 FOUR AXES OF DIVERSITY

FOUR AXES OF DIVERSITY RELIGIOUS DIVERSITY OCCURS ALONG FOUR AXES TRUTH CONTRADICTORY DOCTRINAL CLAIMS SALVATION WHO CAN ATTAIN LIBERATION/SALVATION? EPISTEMIC STATUS ARE OTHERS REASONABLE/JUSTIFIED? CIVIC STATUS WHAT FREEDOM AND EQUALITY ARE OWED?

RELIGIOUS DIVERSITY OCCURS ALONG FOUR AXES truth: contradictory doctrinal claims salvation: who can attain liberation/salvation?

epistemic status: are others reasonable/justified?

civic status: what freedom and equality are owed?

PLURALISM can answer one axis without answering all tolerance is a political/moral practice

SOURCE / DOCTRINE

- RELIGIOUS DIVERSITY OCCURS ALONG FOUR AXES truth: contradictory doctrinal claims salvation: who can attain liberation/salvation?
- epistemic status: are others reasonable/justified?

ARGUMENT / MECHANISM

- civic status: what freedom and equality are owed?
- PLURALISM can answer one axis without answering all tolerance is a political/moral practice

IMPLICATION / VERDICT

- it is not yet a metaphysical claim that all religions are equally true.
- RELIGIOUS DIVERSITY OCCURS ALONG FOUR AXES truth: contradictory doctrinal claims salvation: who can attain liberation/salvation?

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Separate truth, salvation, epistemic access and civic coexistence; success on one axis neither proves nor requires pluralism on the others.

01

STAGE 01 EXCLUSIVISM-INCLUSIVISM-PLURALISM

ONE TRADITION ALONE HAS SAVING TRUTH ONE NORM IS FINAL, BUT GRACE/TRUTH OPERATES BEYOND EXPLICIT MULTIPLE TRADITIONS ARE VALID RESPONSES/ROUTES TO ULTIMATE REALITY STRENGTHS EXCLUSIVISM PRESERVES DETERMINATE TRUTH; INCLUSIVISM WIDENS SALVATION PLURALISM EXPLAINS DIVERSITY AND SUPPORTS HUMILITY COSTS PATRONISING ABSORPTION FLATTENING REAL CONTRADICTIONS EACH MODEL MUST STATE TRUTH CRITERION

EXCLUSIVISM: one tradition alone has saving truth

INCLUSIVISM: one norm is final, but grace/truth operates beyond explicit membership

PLURALISM: multiple traditions are valid responses/routes to ultimate reality strengths: exclusivism preserves determinate truth

inclusivism widens salvation

SOURCE / DOCTRINE

- EXCLUSIVISM: one tradition alone has saving truth
- INCLUSIVISM: one norm is final, but grace/truth operates beyond explicit membership
- PLURALISM: multiple traditions are valid responses/routes to ultimate reality strengths: exclusivism preserves determinate truth

ARGUMENT / MECHANISM

- inclusivism widens salvation
- pluralism explains diversity and supports humility costs: exclusion
- patronising absorption

IMPLICATION / VERDICT

- flattening real contradictions each model must state truth criterion, salvation criterion and view of disagreement.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Exclusivism reserves a decisive norm, inclusivism fulfils others through one centre and pluralism permits several authentic responses or ends.

02

STAGE 02 JOHN HICK

JOHN HICK THE REAL AN SICH (NOUMENAL, BEYOND FULL CONCEPTUAL CAPTURE) PERSONAL REPRESENTATIONS GOD, ALLAH, ISVARA NON-PERSONAL REPRESENTATIONS BRAHMAN, NIRVANA, EMPTINESS RELIGIONS ASSESSED BY TRANSFORMATION FROM SELF-CENTREDNESS KANTIAN DISTINCTION EXPLAINS DIVERSITY WITHOUT DECLARING ALL PROPOSITIONS IDENTICAL HICK IMPOSES A META-THEORY; THE REAL BECOMES UNKNOWNABLE; TRANSFORMATION

THE REAL AN SICH (noumenal, beyond full conceptual capture) culturally shaped human responses

personal representations: God, Allah, Isvara

non-personal representations: Brahman, nirvana, emptiness religions assessed by transformation from self-centredness to Reality-centredness

KANTIAN distinction explains diversity without declaring all propositions identical objections: Hick imposes a meta-theory

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- THE REAL AN SICH (noumenal, beyond full conceptual capture) culturally shaped human responses
- personal representations: God, Allah, Isvara

ARGUMENT / MECHANISM

- non-personal representations: Brahman, nirvana, emptiness religions assessed by transformation from self-centredness to Reality-centredness
- KANTIAN distinction explains diversity without declaring all propositions identical objections: Hick imposes a meta-theory

IMPLICATION / VERDICT

- the Real becomes unknowable
- transformation test is vague.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Hick's Real explains conditioned manifestations, but noumenal unknowability, self-reference and identity-redescription pressure the meta-theory.

03

STAGE 03 VEDĀNTIC MODELS

VEDĀNTIC MODELS ONE BRAHMAN; DIFFERENCES BELONG TO EMPIRICAL STANDPOINT MANY PATHS MAY PREPARE FOR NON-DUAL KNOWLEDGE REAL PLURALITY WITHIN BRAHMAN'S UNITY; DEVOTION TO PERSONAL GOD DIVERSE RELIGIOUS PATHS CAN REALISE ONE ULTIMATE ABSOLUTE-TRUTH PROBLEM IF ALL VIEWS ARE PARTIAL, IS "ALL" REPLY REQUIRES STANDPOINT DISCIPLINE, NOT EFFORTLESS EQUIVALENCE OF INCOMPATIBLE

SYSTEM / DOCTRINE
ADVAITA: one Brahman; differences belong to empirical standpoint
many paths may prepare for non-dual knowledge

DECISIVE DISTINCTION
RĀMĀNUJA: real plurality within Brahman's unity; devotion to personal God remains final
RĀMAKRṢṆA/VIVEKĀNANDA: diverse religious paths can realise one ultimate

EVALUATION / TRAP
ABSOLUTE-TRUTH PROBLEM if all views are partial, is "all are partial" itself absolute?
reply requires standpoint discipline, not effortless equivalence of incompatible claims.

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EVALUATION / TRAP
ABSOLUTE-TRUTH PROBLEM if all views are partial, is "all are partial" itself absolute?
reply requires standpoint discipline, not effortless equivalence of incompatible claims.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Vivekananda and Vedanta support convergence and acceptance, but one neo-Vedantic framework must not erase distinct doctrines or ends.

04

STAGE 04 JAIN MANY-SIDEDNESS

JAIN MANY-SIDEDNESS REALITY HAS MANY ASPECTS EACH FINITE STATEMENT ARISES FROM A STANDPOINT PREDICATE CONDITIONALLY — IN A CERTAIN RESPECT PLURALIST USE RIVAL RELIGIONS MAY DISCLOSE DIFFERENT ASPECTS WITHOUT EXHAUSTIVE POSSESSION EPISTEMIC HUMILITY + NON-VIOLENCE IN JUDGEMENT LIMIT CONTRADICTIONS ARE RECONCILED ONLY IF RESPECTS GENUINELY DIFFER SYĀDVĀDA CANNOT SIMPLY PRONOUNCE EVERY DOCTRINE TRUE IN THE

ANEKĀNTAVĀDA: reality has many aspects

NAYAVĀDA: each finite statement arises from a standpoint

SYĀDVĀDA: predicate conditionally — in a certain respect pluralist use: rival religions may disclose different

possession strength: epistemic humility + non-violence in judgement limit: contradictions are reconciled only if respects

SOURCE / DOCTRINE

- ANEKĀNTAVĀDA: reality has many aspects
- NAYAVĀDA: each finite statement arises from a standpoint

ARGUMENT / MECHANISM

- SYĀDVĀDA: predicate conditionally — in a certain respect pluralist use: rival religions may disclose different aspects without exhaustive
- possession strength: epistemic humility + non-violence in judgement limit: contradictions are reconciled only if respects genuinely differ

IMPLICATION / VERDICT

- syādvāda cannot simply pronounce every doctrine true in the same sense.
- ANEKĀNTAVĀDA: reality has many aspects

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Jain many-sidedness qualifies assertions by standpoint and supports humility without making contradictions true in the same respect.

05

STAGE 05 TOLERANCE AND RELIGIOUS FREEDOM

TOLERANCE AND RELIGIOUS FREEDOM REFRAIN FROM COERCION DESPITE DISAGREEMENT RESPECT RECOGNISE EQUAL STANDING RECIPROCAL REASON-GIVING FREEDOM BELIEF, PRACTICE, CHANGE OF RELIGION, NON-BELIEF, ASSOCIATION LIMITS COERCION HARM TO RIGHTS MAY BE REGULATED BUT OFFENCE OR

TOLERANCE: refrain from coercion despite disagreement respect: recognise equal standing

dialogue: reciprocal reason-giving freedom: belief, practice, change of religion, non-belief, association

LIMITS coercion

harm to rights may be regulated but offence or theological falsity alone is not sufficient

SOURCE / DOCTRINE

- TOLERANCE: refrain from coercion despite disagreement respect: recognise equal standing
- dialogue: reciprocal reason-giving freedom: belief, practice, change of religion, non-belief, association

ARGUMENT / MECHANISM

- LIMITS coercion
- harm to rights may be regulated but offence or theological falsity alone is not sufficient ground for suppression

IMPLICATION / VERDICT

- principled pluralism protects persons and conscience, not every practice from criticism.
- TOLERANCE: refrain from coercion despite disagreement respect: recognise equal standing

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Tolerance and freedom secure equal civic standing under disagreement; they do not prove equal religious truth or salvation.

06

STAGE 06 CONFLICT, UNIFICATION AND DEEP DISAGREEMENT

CONFLICT, UNIFICATION AND DEEP DISAGREEMENT CONFLICT SOURCES EXCLUSIVE REVELATION SACRED HISTORY GRIEVANCE RESPONSES COMMON ETHICAL CORE COMPARATIVE THEOLOGY LEGAL NEUTRALITY

CONFLICT SOURCES: exclusive revelation

sacred history

grievance responses: syncretism

common ethical core

SOURCE / DOCTRINE

- CONFLICT SOURCES: exclusive revelation
- sacred history
- grievance responses: syncretism

ARGUMENT / MECHANISM

- common ethical core
- comparative theology
- legal neutrality

IMPLICATION / VERDICT

- DEEP DISAGREEMENT persists because standards of evidence are tradition-shaped humility != relativism: give reasons, admit fallibility, seek overlap, preserve dissent objections to pluralism: self-refuting, imperial meta-theory, doctrinal dilution reply: modest pluralism can defend equal civic respect
- without equalising every truth claim.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — DEEP DISAGREEMENT persists because standards of evidence are tradition-shaped humility != relativism: give reasons, admit fallibility, seek overlap, preserve dissent objections to pluralism: self-refuting, imperial meta-theory, doctrinal dilution reply: modest pluralism can defend equal civic respect without equalising every truth claim.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Deep disagreement explains persistent divergence and makes dialogue, fallibilism and explicit frameworks rational duties rather than proof of relativism.

07

STAGE 07 PYQ ANSWER SPINE

PYQ ANSWER SPINE DEFINE AXIS MAP EXCLUSIVISM/INCLUSIVISM/PLURALISM EXPLAIN HICK EXACTLY COMPARE ADVAITA/RĀMĀNUJA/JAIN ANEKĀNTA TEST ABSOLUTE-TRUTH OBJECTION MOVE FROM METAPHYSICAL DIVERSITY TO TOLERANCE/FREEDOM WITH LIMITS QUALIFIED CONCLUSION

DEFINE axis — map exclusivism/inclusivism/pluralism — explain Hick exactly

compare Advaita/Rāmānuja/Jain anekānta — test absolute-truth objection

move from metaphysical diversity to tolerance/freedom with limits

qualified conclusion

CLOSE: defensible pluralism is neither "all religions say the same" nor relativism

SOURCE / DOCTRINE

- DEFINE axis — map exclusivism/inclusivism/pluralism — explain Hick exactly
- compare Advaita/Rāmānuja/Jain anekānta — test absolute-truth objection

ARGUMENT / MECHANISM

- move from metaphysical diversity to tolerance/freedom with limits
- qualified conclusion

IMPLICATION / VERDICT

- CLOSE: defensible pluralism is neither "all religions say the same" nor relativism
- it combines truth-seeking, fallibilism, transformative comparison and equal civic liberty.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Defensible pluralism preserves truth constraints, acknowledges hard contradictions and separates metaphysical theory from civic respect.

E

EXTRA SUBORDINATE ENRICHMENT — ONLY AFTER THE COMPLETE CORE

OPTIONAL ADVANCED ENRICHMENT ADVANCED-DOSSIER RECONCILIATION — [OPTIONAL ADVANCED] DOCTRINE STATEMENT. EXCLUSIVISM MAKES ONE TRADITION'S DECISIVE TRUTH/SALVATION CLAIM UNIQUELY VALID INCLUSIVISM GRANTS TRUTH OR SALVATION BEYOND IT WHILE INTERPRETING EXCLUSIVISM APPEALS TO DETERMINATE REVELATION AND NON-CONTRADICTION. INCLUSIVISM ADDS UNIVERSALITY OF DIVINE GRACE WHILE PRESERVING NORMATIVE PRESUPPOSITION. CAUTION

OPTIONAL SOURCE WITNESS

- Advanced-dossier reconciliation — [OPTIONAL ADVANCED]
- Doctrine statement.
- Exclusivism makes one tradition's decisive truth/salvation claim uniquely valid
- inclusivism grants truth or salvation beyond it while interpreting that success through the home tradition.

ADVANCED OBJECTION

- Argument.
- Exclusivism appeals to determinate revelation and non-contradiction.
- Inclusivism adds universality of divine grace while preserving normative priority.
- Presupposition. CAUTION: One revelation has privileged warrant, and salvation can be specified independently enough to compare traditions.

COMPARATIVE NUANCE

- Distinction. Inclusivism is not pluralism: others are included on terms set by the privileged tradition.
- Canonical example. Rahner's "anonymous Christian" is a standard inclusivist model.
- Objection — reply.
- CAUTION: Inclusivism appears patronising.

OPTIONAL STATUS — This optional depth is unnecessary for a competent core answer; use it only for added nuance after the complete core has been written.